

Psalms 132

David's Vow and the Lord's Oath

For the Lord hath chosen Zion; he hath desired it for his habitation

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 LORD, remember David, and all his afflictions:
- 2 How he sware unto the LORD, and vowed unto the mighty God of Jacob;
- 3 Surely I will not come into the tabernacle of my house, nor go up into my bed;
- 4 I will not give sleep to mine eyes, or slumber to mine eyelids,
- 5 Until I find out a place for the LORD, an habitation for the mighty God of Jacob.
- 6 Lo, we heard of it at Ephratah: we found it in the fields of the wood.
- 7 We will go into his tabernacles: we will worship at his footstool.
- 8 Arise, O LORD, into thy rest; thou, and the ark of thy strength.
- 9 Let thy priests be clothed with righteousness; and let thy saints shout for joy.
- 10 For thy servant David's sake turn not away the face of thine anointed.
- 11 The LORD hath sworn in truth unto David; he will not turn from it; Of the fruit of thy body will I set upon thy throne.
- 12 If thy children will keep my covenant and my testimony that I shall teach them, their children shall also sit upon thy throne for evermore.
- 13 For the LORD hath chosen Zion; he hath desired it for his habitation.
- 14 This is my rest for ever: here will I dwell; for I have desired it.
- 15 I will abundantly bless her provision: I will satisfy her poor with bread.
- 16 I will also clothe her priests with salvation: and her saints shall shout aloud for joy.
- 17 There will I make the horn of David to bud: I have ordained a lamp for mine anointed.
- 18 His enemies will I clothe with shame: but upon himself shall his crown flourish.

2 · CONTEXT

Psalms 132 is a Song of Ascents built around two intertwined promises: David's own oath to find a resting place for the ark of the covenant (recalling 2 Samuel 6–7), and the Lord's reciprocal oath to establish David's throne and make Zion His own dwelling place forever. Pilgrims ascending to Jerusalem would have sung this as a rehearsal of covenant history, grounding their worship not in vague piety but in specific, remembered promises. Henry treats the psalm as a model of prayer that pleads God's own commitments back to Him; MacArthur-style notes see its Davidic covenant language pointing toward the greater, permanent King it ultimately anticipates.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-5

The psalm opens by recalling David's own vow—sworn with striking intensity, refusing sleep or rest to his eyes and eyelids—until he found a place for the ark, a habitation for the God of Jacob. Human devotion is pictured as costly and deliberate, not casual.

Verse 6-10

The ark's journey is recalled through place names—Ephratah, the fields of the wood—and the pilgrims' own resolve echoes David's: let us go into His tabernacle and worship at His footstool. The plea turns toward the Lord: arise into your rest, let priests be clothed with righteousness, let saints shout for joy, for the sake of your servant David, do not turn away your anointed.

Verse 11-12

The Lord's own oath is quoted directly: He swore to David in truth that his own offspring would sit on his throne, conditioned specifically on the children keeping His covenant and testimony. Blessing is bound to continued faithfulness, not granted unconditionally to the dynasty as a formality.

Verse 13-16

The reason behind the promise surfaces: the Lord has chosen Zion, desired it for His own habitation, calling it His rest forever. Provision follows this choice—abundant blessing, satisfied poor, priests clothed with salvation, saints shouting aloud for joy—Zion's welfare flowing directly from being God's chosen dwelling.

Verse 17-18

The psalm closes with promises for David specifically: his horn will bud there, a lamp is ordained for His anointed, enemies will be clothed with shame, while his own crown flourishes. The closing image ties dynastic hope directly to God's presence in Zion rather than to any independent political strength.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Covenant faithfulness runs in both directions in this psalm: David's costly devotion to give God a resting place is met by God's own sworn commitment to establish David's line and make Zion His permanent dwelling. Worship here is not generic sentiment but a rehearsal of specific, historical promises, reminding pilgrims that their hope rests on what God has actually said and sworn, not merely on pious feeling.

Application for life today.

Consider what costly, deliberate devotion—like David's vow in verses 3–5—God may be asking of you, rather than a casual or convenient faith. When you pray, practice pleading God's own past promises back to Him, as this psalm does, rather than relying only on vague hope. Let the conditional language of verse 12 examine whether your own faithfulness is keeping pace with the blessings you are asking God to continue.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What would a vow of costly, deliberate devotion—like David's refusal to rest until he found God a dwelling place (vv. 3–5)—look like in your own life right now?

2. How does grounding prayer in God's specific, remembered promises, rather than vague hope, change the way you might pray this week?

3. Where does verse 12's conditional link between blessing and covenant faithfulness challenge you to examine your own obedience?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).